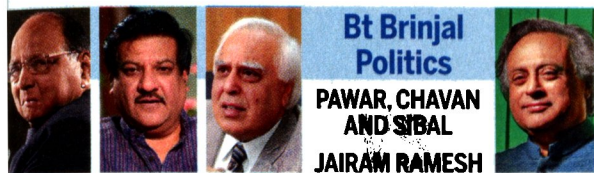


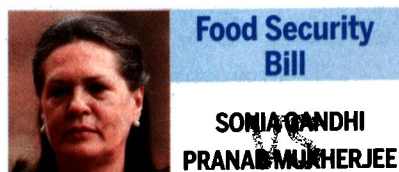
Instead of governance, it is regional egos and petty turf wars that are keeping the Prime Minister's men busy



The trio of Sharad Pawar, Prithviraj Chavan and Kapil Sibal were critical of Ramesh's no to Bt brinjal, saying scientists, not ministers, should be trusted on science.



Ramesh criticised the NHAI for its poor aforestation record; Nath had complained that delayed environmental clearances were stalling ministry projects.



Sonia not happy with draft Bill. To fund her plan of 35 kg grain at Rs 3 per kg, the finance ministry has to cough up Rs 30,000 crore more.



Mukherjee and Deora are at war over the pricing of petroleum products



Mamata was in tears when Mukherjee refused her last minute clearance for 24 rail projects.

chunk of the 81 seats. Unless the seat adjustment meets her approval, Trinamool sources say she will not commit to the nuclear bill. The prime minister needs the support of her 19 MPs to ensure that the bill is not defeated when it is introduced. Lack of numbers was the reason why the Government was forced to defer the introduction of the bill on March 15 even though it was listed for the day. The mercurial Mamata has already blocked one of Sonia's favourite legislations, the Land Acquisition (Amendment) Bill. In February, during a Cabinet Committee on Infrastructure meet, she took the Cabinet by surprise when she wanted a last-minute approval of 24 rail projects estimated at Rs 15,000 crore. An exasperated Mukherjee told her that "this is not the way the Government functions". Unnerved by his reprimand, Mamata burst into tears as another Cabinet colleague Kumari Selja rushed to hug her while Vilasrao Deshmukh handed her his starched white handkerchief.

But if not girlish tears then it's schoolboyish pranks that keeps the Prime Minister's men busy. On April 24, the BJP disrupted the Rajya Sabha for over 10 minutes over the frequent absence of the DMK's Chemical and Fertiliser Minister M.K. Azhagiri. Yet there is little the prime minister can do about team members in the playing XI who are wearing allied colours as half a dozen Congress ministers regularly bunk meetings.

Sometimes the equation gets further muddled with association. NCP's Sharad Pawar has always been a big supporter of Manmohan, whether in the 1991 Rao cabinet where he backed him on reforms or in the 2004 Cabinet where Congress ministers challenged his bestowed authority. So when the NCP strongman faced barbs over rising prices, Manmohan was quick to defend him. You could say he is following the dictum of collective responsibility that Pawar quoted, or you could say he is following the need of coalition dharma where you support current allies till you find others. As the nation was rocked by allegations and counter allegations of the IPL scandal, the Opposition rose to the occasion and demanded a Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC). The timing was critical. Although the NCP has just nine MPs, every vote counts. Worse, the Congress cannot afford to lose Maharashtra. The saving grace is, Manmohan also counts on the Maratha leader's emotional support. Whether it is on the issue of disinvestment, the nuclear bill or even women's reservation, the NCP is yet to oppose the Prime Minister unlike the DMK and Trinamool which have not allowed any PSU disinvestment to take place in their states, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal. Similarly, wary of angering both these parties, the Government also delayed the Pension Bill as it could upset the trade unions in the two states.



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